

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

USAP Community School_Zimbabwe_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

USAP Community School

Fellowship City

Ruwa

Fellowship Country

Zimbabwe

Fellowship Start Date

07/25/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/25/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Instructor/Faculty (Research Methods, Capstone, Music Theory)

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Teaching research methods, Senior Capstone/college counseling, and music theory at residential low-resource, high-achieving rural A-Level (lower and upper Sixth form) school in Zimbabwe
- Re-structuring school health systems, developing custom electronic medical record, and assisting with student/faculty medical care
- Leading extracurricular activities (first aid and creatives), performing faculty other duties

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

I received an orientation with the Head of the School before I arrived, as well as after I arrived. He answered any and all questions I had via email, then we went over rules/faculty handbook.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?
Describe a representative day at work.

I wake up around 7 AM, breakfast at 7:40 AM. I teach around 2 classes a day (each 1 hour). Throughout the day, I have meetings with students, lesson prep, informal meetings with faculty. Class ends around 3. I usually lead an extracurricular after class. Then, I have meetings, prep lessons until dinner at 6. After dinner, I sit in the office from 7-10 for student study time and offer office hours.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

70-98

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Very Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

1. I have rebuilt the school's health system.
2. I have started a music theory course.

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

The office is an open space with 14 desks and a couch. All teachers usually sit in the office and students come in with questions. The office also extends to the classrooms and outdoors.

To whom do you report?

Head of School. I report to him with questions and concerns.
Co-founder and Co-Capstone teacher. I report to her regarding Capstone and college counseling

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.
Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

1. Complete health systems rebuild
2. Revamp research methods course for L6 students
3. Expand music theory course

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?
Please provide more information on your response above.

1. I want to continue building the electronic medical record for the school, acquire medical equipment, and develop training for teachers.
2. I want to improve the quantitative methods course for the L6 students.
3. I want to expand the music theory course to introductory and advanced level courses.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

Informal travel to Ruwa and Harare, for school purchases, school activities, etc.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I feel that my college and work experience prepared me extremely well to manage work. I find that students and faculty often rely on me as I am effective at problem solving.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

Head of school purchased a ticket via Expedia. I flew from Chicago to Addis Ababa, then from Addis to Harare. The one-way ticket costed \$1130.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I currently have a visitor's visa and have applied for a temporary employment permit (TEP).

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Obtained visitor's visa at the airport. The TEP was submitted to the Dept of Immigration through one of USAP's immigration consultants.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

Applied for the TEP after arriving.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$30 for the visitor's visa. I am not sure how much the TEP is -- the school covers the costs.

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Covered by the organization.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

The TEP is still a work in progress. For now, I am renewing my visitor's visa.

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

I recommend beginning the document process as soon as you accept the fellowship post. I waited until June (after I graduated). I also suggest having all the correct steps to apply, which I can provide

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

Meningitis, typhoid. Insurance covered the cost, so I am not sure.

I received yellow fever vaccine only after I arrived in Zimbabwe.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

It was difficult. Water, power, and wifi were all out the day I arrived. Coming to Zim with an open mind.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing provided by school -- it is a boarding school.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Rural

Please describe your living environment

The current school is a converted lodge in rural Zimbabwe. It is very forest-like.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

No travel, no cost.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

The closest town is Ruwa with small grocery stores and small pharmacy. It is not within walking distance. I usually take the school car or public transport to town. It takes 15 minutes driving, public transport around 30 minutes (15 minutes to walk to the bus stop). Transport is less than \$1 USD.

The nearest city with shopping, airport, medical centers is Harare, a 45 minute drive. Public transport in private cars/combi is \$1USD.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

It is quite warm -- it feels like Palo Alto. We are currently in summer, 26C. Winter is around 10C.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

I wear polo/button-down and pants/shorts to work. I used to wear Allbirds, but now I wear Birkenstocks. This is appropriate for work. Outside of work, I can typically wear anything (t-shirt and shorts).

How have you been spending your free time?

I have little free time. On campus, I generally read, knit/crochet, watch Hulu, or call friends from home. If I can go into town, I shop. It is hard to socialize with students/faculty while trying to maintain a professional relationship.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Disagree

Please briefly explain your response below.

This has been difficult. It is very difficult to share personal details about myself while still maintaining a professional relationship with students/teachers. I don't have a social life outside of school. I rely on my friends from home for support - calling them and messaging them daily.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Campus is very safe, there are guards and little to no crime.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I pack lightly and tightly, bring little money, and always bring a teacher/TA with me wherever I go.

No crime.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Crime is not frequent at school. Crime is common in Harare, though, depending where you go and who you are. When I travel outside, I always bring a local Zimbabwean with me.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I wanted to immerse myself in the local Zimbabwean communities, which I have certainly done with the support of students and faculty.

I wanted to work on having a balance between work and life, which has been very difficult. I find it challenging to say no - but I am still working on it.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

Yes, I have had frustrations with living arrangements. The living quarters are small -- I share a thin wall with 3 TAs, and live right across from the school and the student dorms. Water often goes out, and so does power/WiFi.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

No.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I rely on Rebecca, my advisor, who often listens and helps me when I am finding things difficult. I also rely on my friends from home a lot.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I enjoy teaching. I get the opportunity to teach what I love (research methods, mentoring senior thesis and college counseling), while also getting to bring other of my interests to school (music, arts/crafts like knitting/crocheting, photography/videography, health, etc.). I feel like I can be creative while also giving students the tools/skills to do new things.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

It has been challenging to set boundaries and say no. I find that faculty often ask me to do tasks that do not fall in my role description, because they know I have a difficult time saying no to them.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

1. I miss food (mom's Indian food, Chinese take-out, etc.)
2. I miss living situation (water pressure, peace and quiet in my room, privacy)
3. I miss the lack of bugs

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

1. The hospitality
2. The fresh fruits and vegetables / cost of food
3. The access to hikes/walks with gorgeous views.

How is your stipend being paid?

I get paid \$250 USD per month to my US account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$10.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$20.00	\$0.00	\$50.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$5.00	\$0.00	\$10.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	85.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

Orientation covered a lot of topics, some which I think were not too useful, but I am sure will be in the future.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

How to navigate work/life balance, saying no and setting boundaries in the work place (even though we are fellows who are doing service work), how to live with less amenities.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

How to boundary set, ideas for fun things to do on the continent.